in December 1996,[61] India opened a field hospital at the Farkhor air base in south Tajikistan in early 1999, close to the Afghan border.[62] Given the limited impact of such covert Indian support to the United Front, either before or after the rise of the Taliban in Kabul, it is clear that Rao did ameliorate R&AW's operations in Afghanistan in comparison with Rajiv's interventionism, but did not abandon them. From this perspective, Pakistan's claim about India's role in Afghanistan was correct, even if exaggerated.

American journalist Steve Coll concurs that India gave US$ 10 million in cash to Massoud sometime after 1999.[63] Declassified US diplomatic cable and intelligence dossiers also confirm India's provision of weapons to the UF. However, dates of such transactions are still kept classified in these cables (erased by a black marker).[64] According to a former Massoud loyalist who facilitated this relationship, 'India's help was mostly in terms of cash and medical supplies'.[65] India chipped in to the UF's kitty, which needed between US$ 2–3 million per month to survive and fight the Taliban.[66] Strictly speaking, it can be argued that India provided 'non-lethal' military support to the UF. However, given the critical role that this support played in keeping the UF afloat, the concept of lethality is metaphysical at best. What is of import is the limited nature of this support (jointly with Iran and Russia). In comparison to India's heavy military engagement either in Bangladesh in 1971 or Sri Lanka in the late 1980s and afterwards, its assistance to the UF was miniscule. As former US Assistant Secretary of State for South Asian Affairs Karl Inderfurth stated in March 1999, most of such support was coming from Russia and Iran, and that too was uncertain. 'Iran and Russia [and by implication India too] are more likely to end diplomatic and covert support to [Massoud] than Pakistan would be to end its support to the Taliban', he wrote in a secret report to the White House.[67] There was no guarantee of India's sustained military support to Massoud if 9/11 had not happened. X, India's secret agent in Afghanistan agrees that India's support to the UF, in collaboration with Iran and Russia, was not sufficient and may not have lasted very long. 'We were a poor country, and were barely managing to provide them [UF] support. Pakistan was more committed to the Taliban, and had the advantage of geography,' he admits.[68]